



AMD Processors

AMD coined a new term in the processor segment called the Accelerated Processing Unit (APU) which is a fancy term for processors with integrated graphics and lay heavy stress on power efficiency. Under this Fusion APU series, AMD first launched an Intel Atom competitor by the code name Zacate, which is a low power processor ideal for HTPC setups. This series was followed by a mid-range processor lineup codenamed Llano. The flagship Llano APU (A8-3850) has a dedicated graphics HD 6550D chipset which house 400 stream processors - quite impressive for mid-range gaming.

Zero1 Winner AMD FX-8150

AMD launched its flagship model, an 8-core processor a couple of months ago. Targetted at the higher-end enthusiast community the FX series of processors don't support integrated graphics. Each Bulldozer module comprises two integer cores, and four such Bulldozer modules make the processor. Performance-wise, it was only slightly better than the Intel Core i5-2500K and slower than the Core i7-2600K. As far as AMD processors are concerned, this is the best processor yet.

Worthy Mention AMD A8-3850

If you want a decent processor that will allow you to game at 1680x1050, without a discrete graphics card, then A8-3850 is the processor to go to. As far as gaming goes, the HD 6550D in the A8-3850 gives better frame rates when compared to Intel's HD 2000 / HD 3000. It can be CrossFired with three AMD graphics cards such as HD6670, HD 6570 and HD 6450, this boosts the frame rates further.



◀ MOTHERBOARD: ASUS CROSSHAIR V FORMULA Price: ₹15,900



AMD A8-3850 Price: ₹7,425



ASRock A75 Extreme6 Price: ₹ 7,500

Motherboards

We saw two chipsets this year, namely the 890FX and 990FX. The 990FX was introduced in the second half of this year with the main differences being compatibility with AM3+ based CPUs (read: Bulldozer FX series processors) and NVIDIA SLI support for AMD processors. The SLI support is a big selling point of this chipset as you'll not be locked onto the AMD eco-system if you get an AMD processor. The other chipset for the Llano processors was the A75 chipset.

Zero1 Winner ASUS ROG Crosshair V Formula

The Republic of Gamers series is packed to the gills with features. ASUS Crosshair V Formula continues that legacy. The build quality is rock-solid with sturdy heat sinks. ASUS's implementation of the UEFI BIOS is the best we've come across and makes tweaking the BIOS very easy. The ROG overclocking features coupled with the AI Suite's prowess, allows you to monitor and tweak your system settings from the OS environment. The dedicated overclocking button beside the power and reset button is an interesting addition allowing you to overclock without entering the BIOS. The only hitch which we can think of is the absence of a POST error code LED, an extra LAN port which would have also been nice considering it's the flagship board from ASUS.

Worthy Mention ASRock A75 Extreme6

As far as the Llano boards go, we found this board to be the best in terms of overall feature set. It has around eight SATA 6Gbps ports, POST debug LED and start/reset buttons, among other things. This, bundled with the well laid out UEFI BIOS adds to the goodies. Performance wise it is slightly better than competitors but its feature set far outnumbers everyone.



◀ AMD CPU: AMD FX-8150 Price: ₹15,500